

Things that COME UP *in the night*

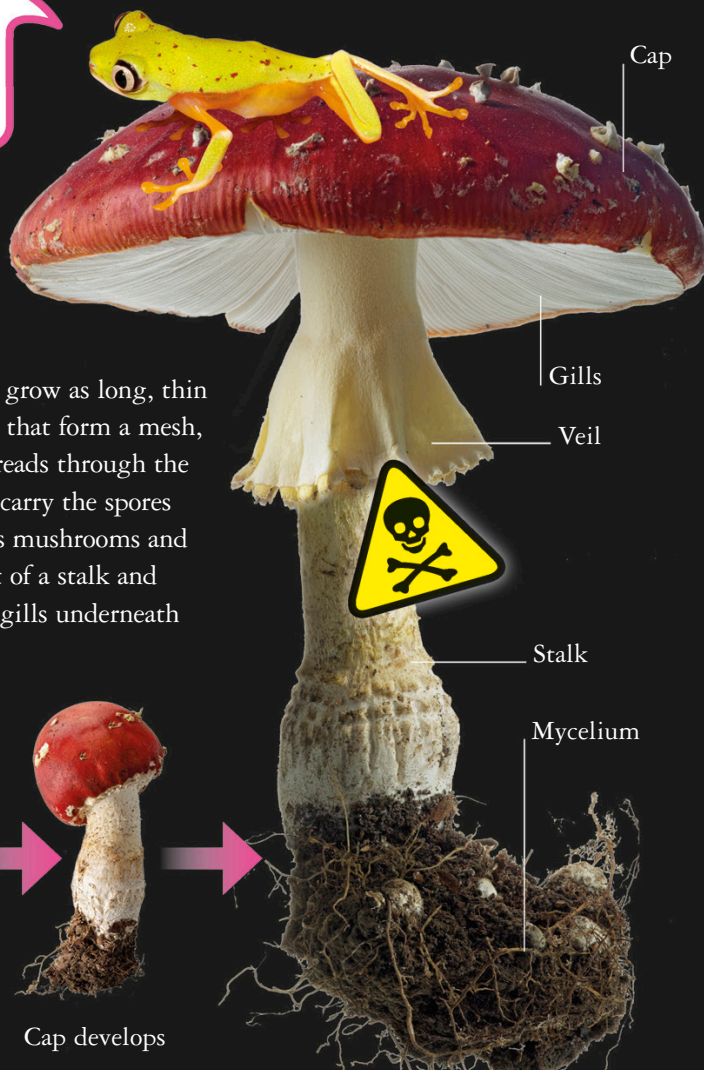
IT'S A BIT OF AN ANIMAL

For many years, scientists classed fungi as part of the plant kingdom. In fact, they are closer to animals. The cell walls of fungi are made of chitin, which is found in the shells of insects and crustaceans. They also store food as glycogen, a carbohydrate found in the muscles and liver of animals. Plants, by contrast, have cell walls made of cellulose and store food as starch.

Never eat a wild mushroom that hasn't been identified as safe by an expert!

Anatomy of a fungus

You rarely see all of a fungus since most of it lies underground. Most grow as long, thin filaments called hyphae that form a mesh, or mycelium, which threads through the soil. Only the bits that carry the spores emerge above ground as mushrooms and toadstools. They consist of a stalk and a cap, sac, or cup, with gills underneath that contain the spores.



Toadstool emerges



Cap develops

Mushrooms

Mushrooms and toadstools are the fruiting bodies of underground fungi and come in a wide variety of shapes, resembling umbrellas, pancakes, puffballs, or shrivelled fruits. Some mushrooms, such as morels and truffles, can be eaten and are a good source of protein—and delicious! But other species, like the Jack O'Lantern, are extremely poisonous. Others produce vivid colors that can be used to dye textiles and paper.



Fungi cannot make their own food so they get it from the soil or by breaking down dead matter. Saprophytes are fungi that secrete enzymes to extract the nutrients they need. Other types of fungi are parasitic—they get their nutrients by growing on a living host, such as a tree. The tree gains extra nutrients from the fungus's mycelium and the fungus gets food from the tree.